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THE SWITCH Jyotiraditya Scindia and other rebel Congress leaders with BJP president J.P. Nadda after joining the party, Mar. 2020

mats for meetings, he would gladly do it. This statement was construed as a farewell speech by Chouhan but, again, nothing happened subsequently. Political observers have developed another pastime in the past few months—reading Chouhan's body language. Every time the CM smiles less or has droopy shoulders, the Mantralaya comes alive with replacement theories.

Madhya Pradesh will be witness to a high-stakes assembly election in November this year. The BJP has been in power in MP since December 2003, except for a brief 15-month rule by the Congress in 2019-2020—which it brought to an end by wooing then Congress leader Jyotiraditya Scindia over to its side along with 22 MLAs. Now, with the Congress sparing no effort to reverse the situation, what the BJP does with its leadership will be crucial.

The party's state unit chief, V.D. Sharma, though not as well known outside MP as Chouhan, is another key variable in the mix. The Khajuraho Lok Sabha MP, with his roots in the students' organisation ABVP, retains the aggressive, agitation-based political style characteristic of an RSS affiliate. His appointment in February 2020, during Congress rule, was clearly aimed at using his skills to take on the government of the day. That March, when power changed hands and Chouhan returned as CM, the equations got a trifle complex.

It's an open secret in Bhopal that Chouhan and Sharma share a 'lukewarm' relationship at best. Put it down to an implicit sense of rivalry—after all, Sharma's appointment was perceived by commentators as an attempt to bring in a fresh leadership in the state after the BJP's December 2018 defeat. Indeed, in the first few months of Chouhan's new tenure, Sharma stayed in the ascendant, exercising great influence over the government. The situation changed after the party won 19 out of 28 seats in byelections held in November 2020. Chouhan began to assert himself again. Only problem was, Sharma was by then posing to be an emerging star and could not hide his ambitions.

Chouhan has faced three assembly elections, in 2008, 2013 and 2018. In the first two, he had Narendra Singh Tomar as state party president. The duo enjoyed a great working rapport. In 2018, Chouhan went into elections with Jabalpur MP Rakesh Singh as state party chief. The working relationship between the two wasn't exactly strained, but the chemistry Chouhan and Tomar had wasn't there either. The BJP had lost that election. "While the responsibilities of the CM and state BJP president are clearly defined, during elections, their rapport or lack of it can have a bearing on candidate selection. In 2023, given that the Congress has not been able to pin down the election on an issue, candidate selection will be of utmost importance for both parties," says political analyst Girija Shankar. Against this background, observers feel the CM and state chief need to be on the same page on all matters. This brings Sharma's tenure into focus, assuming Chouhan continues.

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There are other factors too that will have a bearing on the continuation of the BJP state president, such as a Union cabinet expansion and caste arithmetic. There is talk in Madhya Pradesh that the party may be looking at a tribal state president given the new emphasis on winning back Adivasi votes. The names of Union minister Faggan Singh Kulaste and MP Sumer Singh Solanki are thus doing the rounds as probables.

There is one factor weighing in favour of Sharma's continuation. During the BJP national executive meet on January 16-17, national president J.P. Nadda was given an extension in office till June 2024, ensuring that the next Lok Sabha election is held under his stewardship. This nod to continuity could give hope to the state BJP chiefs in MP and eight other states that have assembly elections lined up